



Christopher You

PhD Candidate · Human-Centered Computing

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Skills

AI/ML LLMs, PyTorch, HuggingFace Transformers, Scikit, RAG, Prompt Engineering, Embeddings, LLM Evaluation Pipelines, Fine-Tuning, Tool-Calling, Model Evaluation, Benchmarking, Human-in-the-Loop Frameworks

Systems Agentic Workflows, Embodied Conversational AI Systems, Human-AI Collaboration, VR/AR/XR

Infrastructure AWS, Cloud-hosted Web Systems, Google Cloud, REST APIs, Scalable Backend Architectures, Web Frameworks (Node.js, React, Express), Mongo, SQL/RDS

Research Development Qualitative/Quantitative Methods, Statistical Modeling (Python, R, SPSS), Power Analysis, Experimental Design, Git, CI/CD Workflows, QA Systems, API Integrations, Full-Stack Web Development, Distributed Systems, MCPs

Summary

PhD candidate in Human-Centered Computing specializing in applied AI systems that support human decision-making and behavior change. Experienced in designing and deploying production conversational AI platforms integrating LLM pipelines, retrieval systems, and human-AI collaborative workflows. Built large-scale web systems used in healthcare research and university curriculum, supporting real users through AI-mediated interactions. Combines technical system development with experimental evaluation to ensure reliability, engagement, and impact.

Education

Ph.D. in Human-Centered Computing

University of Florida

Advisor: Dr. Benjamin Lok

Gainesville, Florida

Aug 2020 - May 2026

GPA: 3.8

M.S. in Computer Science

University of Florida

Advisor: Dr. Benjamin Lok

Gainesville, Florida

Aug 2020 - Dec 2022

GPA: 3.8

B.S. in Computer Science

University of Minnesota

Advisor: Dr. Evan Suma Rosenberg

Minneapolis, Minnesota

Sep 2018 - May 2020

GPA: 3.8

Experience

Research Assistant

Virtual Experiences Research Group

University of Florida

Aug 2020 - Current

- Broad impacts of HCI & applied AI research: (1) improving care for patients with severe psychiatric disorders (**NIH R34 Grant**), (2) clinical trial enrollment for cancer populations (**NIH R24/U01 Grant**), (3) creation of patient simulations for university curriculum, and (4) promotion of mental health and well-being.
- Launched "Build-a-Being Yourself", a web-based conversational AI platform to support healthcare research, enabling domain experts to rapidly deploy conversational interventions at scale.
- Implemented agent-driven interaction workflows coordinating multiple reasoning stages, including dialogue planning, strategy selection, and response generation.

- Built evaluation pipelines for conversational AI, analyzing model outputs, user engagement metrics, and behavioral outcomes.
- Integrated user-state modeling, human-AI collaborative frameworks, LLMs, fine-tuning, and virtual reality technologies into research protocols.
- Mentored undergraduate and graduate students on research and experimental design, AI systems and development, and publications.

Teaching Assistant CEN4722: User Experience Design

University of Florida
Jan 2024 - May 2024

- Designed coursework and projects for the CEN4722: User Experience Design course, enhancing student engagement.
- Developed weekly assigned readings to support course objectives and foster critical thinking.
- Collaborated with faculty in planning lectures and course activities, ensuring a cohesive learning experience.

Research Assistant Davidson DRiVE Lab

Davidson College
May 2022 - Aug 2022

- Conducted in-depth research on embodiment and agency in avatars within VR and desktop environments.
- Published two articles contributing to the academic discourse in VR.
- Mentored undergraduate students in VR/AR development, enhancing their skills under the guidance of Dr. Tabitha Peck.

Software Engineering Intern Amazon

Seattle, Washington
May 2020 - Aug 2020

- Tasked with designing innovative solutions for Amazon Help Services and Alexa Services.
- Integrated search capability via knowledge graph and NLP capabilities.
- Developed front-end, back-end stack compatible with SPARQL to generate query response.

Research Assistant Illusioneering Lab

University of Minnesota
Oct 2018 - May 2020

- Developed programming skills in C# using Unity to explore practical applications of VR systems.
- Collaborated with graduate students on pilot tests and lab meetings to enhance VR research.
- Published "Strafing Gains," a technique supporting locomotion in VR, contributing to the field's advancement.

Publications

Journal Proceedings

- [3] **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Vilaro, M., Venkatakrishnan, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Maxim, A., Peng, X., Tamboli, D., & Lok, B. (2025). Alter egos alter engagement: Perspective-taking can improve disclosure quantity and depth to ai chatbots in promoting mental wellbeing. *Frontiers in Digital Health*, 7, 1655860
- [2] **You, C.**, Venkatakrishnan, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Han, Z., Lok, B., & Peck, T. (2024). A sense of urgency on the sense of agency: Challenges in evaluating agency and embodiment in virtual reality. *IEEE Transactions on Visualization and Computer Graphics*
- [1] **You, C.**, Peck, T., Stuart, J., Gomes de Siqueira, A., & Lok, B. (2024). What my bias meant for my embodiment: An investigation on virtual embodiment in desktop-based virtual reality. *Frontiers in Virtual Reality*, 5, 1251564

Conference Proceedings

- [6] **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Canales, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Vilaro, M., & Lok, B. (In preparation). Human-ai collaboration and user-state modeling transparency promotes engagement in mental health conversations. *Proceedings of the 25th ACM conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing*, 1-8

- [5] **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Maxim, A., Peng, X., Tamboli, D., Huang, Z., & Lok, B. (To Appear). Build-a-being yourself: A practical system and method for embodied conversational agents in web-based research. *Proceedings of the 28th International Conference on Human-Computer Interaction*, 1–15
- [4] Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Venkatakrishnan, R., & Lok, B. (2025b). The impact of health literacy in a virtual agent intervention addressing barriers to cancer clinical trial participation. *Proceedings of the 13th International Conference on Human-Agent Interaction*, 76–86
- [3] Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Venkatakrishnan, R., & Lok, B. (2025a). Exploring the influence of multiple virtual agents for addressing barriers to cancer clinical trial participation. *Proceedings of the 25th ACM International Conference on Intelligent Virtual Agents*, 1–10
- [2] **You, C.**, Benda, B., Rosenberg, E. S., Ragan, E., Lok, B., & Thomas, J. (2022). Strafing gain: Redirecting users one diagonal step at a time. *2022 IEEE international symposium on mixed and augmented reality (ISMAR)*, 603–611
- [1] **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Maxim, A., Stuart, J., Cooks, E., & Lok, B. (2022). How does a virtual human earn your trust? guidelines to improve willingness to self-disclose to intelligent virtual agents. *Proceedings of the 22nd ACM International Conference on Intelligent Virtual Agents*, 1–8

Posters, Abstracts, & Demos

- [8] Kauer, T., Franco, C., Munroe, D., Flood-Grady, E., Gaillard, T., George, T., Lin, T., Lok, B., Tucker, C., Vilaro, M., Webb, F., Wilke, D., Wilson-Howard, D., Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Serat, J., Buhr, M., Murphy, C., van Mossel, A., ... Krieger, J. (2025). Representation matters: The feasibility and impact of photo-realistic and social identity-matched virtual community health educators among black, hispanic, and rural adults. *Science of Community Outreach and Engagement Annual Conference*, 1
- [7] Huynh, L., **You, C.**, Mazorra, G., Black, E., Lok, B., & Blue, A. (2025). A patient chatbot to support interprofessional learning. [Oral presentation]. *Collaborating Across Borders IX*, 1
- [6] Munroe, D., Kauer, T., Franco, C., Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Ford, H., Lok, B., & Krieger, J. L. (2025). Connecting communities: Developing a provider portal to enhance cancer trial diversity. *Science of Communication Outreach and Engagement Annual Conference*, 1
- [5] Kauer, T., Franco, C., Lok, B., Tucker, C., Lin, T., Flood-Grady, E., Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Wilson-Howard, D., Gaillard, T., Anton, S., & Krieger, J. (2025). Connecting older adults to clinical trials: Developing the alex clinical trial referral portal. *14th Annual Alliance Meeting for Healthy Aging Conference*, 1
- [4] Kauer, T., Franco, C., Munroe, D., Flood-Grady, E., Gaillard, T., Lin, T., Lok, B., Tucker, C., Wilson-Howard, D., Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Serat, J., Buhr, M., Wynter, S., Anton, S., & Krieger, J. (2025). A strengths- and community-based approach to increasing medical research participation among black, hispanic, and white rural populations in florida [poster presentation]. *Mayo Clinic Transforming Community and Rural Healthcare 2025 Conference, Rochester, MN*, 1
- [3] Ghosh, R., Maxim, A., **You, C.**, & Lok, B. (2024). Real-time virtual human for promoting clinical trial education and recruitment. *2024 IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces Abstracts and Workshops (VRW)*, 1184–1185
- [2] Jurczyk, K., **You, C.**, Nourani, M., Gupta, M., Anthony, L., & Lok, B. (2021). Romadoro: Leveraging nudge techniques to encourage break-taking. *Adjunct Proceedings of the 34th Annual ACM Symposium on User Interface Software and Technology*, 66–69
- [1] **You, C.**, Suma Rosenberg, E., & Thomas, J. (2019). Strafing gain: A novel redirected walking technique. *Symposium on Spatial User Interaction*, 1–1

Undergraduate-Mentored Articles

Undergraduate journal publications authored by students whom I directly mentored on a weekly basis throughout the project and manuscript development.

- [2] Huynh, L., Blue, A., **You, C.**, Lok, B., Smith, G., Ghosh, R., & Venkatakrishnan, R. (2025). A feasibility study to assess virtual patients authenticity on building confidence in students' clinical decision-making. *UF Journal of Undergraduate Research*, 27
- [1] Smith, G., Huynh, L., **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., & Lok, B. (2025). Evaluating lip synchronization techniques in llm-based virtual humans for healthcare and computer science applications. *UF Journal of Undergraduate Research*, 27

Presentations and Invited Talks

Jan 2026	Newspaper Interview , When ChatGPT becomes a crisis helpline	<i>The Independent Alligator</i>
Mar 2025	Guest Talk , Embodied experiences to improve online virtual human mental health interventions	<i>Illusioneering Lab, UMN</i>
Oct 2024	Conference , A sense of urgency on the sense of agency: challenges in evaluating agency and embodiment in virtual reality.	<i>IEEE ISMAR</i>
Mar 2024	Consortium , Using the health belief model to tailor virtual humans for clinical trials	<i>IEEE VR</i>
Jun 2023	Guest Lecture , Strafing gain: Redirecting users one diagonal step at a time	<i>CEN4721 - HCI</i>
Oct 2022	Conference , Strafing gain: Redirecting users one diagonal step at a time	<i>IEEE ISMAR</i>
Sep 2022	Conference , How does a virtual human earn your trust? guidelines to improve willingness to self-disclose to intelligent virtual agents.	<i>ACM IVA</i>
Oct 2019	Poster , Strafing gain: A novel redirected walking technique	<i>ACM SUI</i>

Funding Received

2023 - 2026	Generation NEXT Fellowship , \$10,000	<i>University of Florida</i>
2024 - 2025	Computer & Information Science & Engineering Scholarship , \$2,500	<i>University of Florida</i>
2021 - 2022	Olson-Mitchell STEM Translational Communications Project Award , \$5,000	<i>University of Florida</i>
2020 - 2026	Graduate School Preeminence Award , \$36,000/yr	<i>University of Florida</i>
2019 - 2020	Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program Award , \$4,000	<i>University of Minnesota</i>

Services and Professional Activities

Mentoring

2022 - 2025	Leyna Huynh , Published article in Journal of Undergraduate Research	<i>University of Florida</i>
2022 - 2025	Gaby Smith , Published article in Journal of Undergraduate Research	<i>University of Florida</i>
2024 - 2025	Lucas John , Nutrition Module Project	<i>University of Florida</i>
2024 - 2025	Abbhinav Sriram , Build-a-Being Yourself Project	<i>University of Florida</i>
2022 - 2024	Tarun Desari , Presentation at Undergraduate Research Symposium	<i>University of Florida</i>
2022 - 2023	Zhuoming Han , Co-authored "A Sense of Urgency:..."	<i>University of Florida</i>

Student Volunteering

2024	Paper Session , International Symposium on Mixed and Augmented Reality	<i>IEEE ISMAR</i>
2024	DEIA Accessibility Streaming , Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces	<i>IEEE VR</i>
2019	Paper Session , Symposium on Spatial User Interaction	<i>ACM SUI</i>